



ALL THAT GLITTERS

Inspired by how people flaunt their jewellery during the wedding season, Sabyasachi believes his wedding jewellery line has the potential to surpass his wedding couture business

story without apology". "I would never do a collaboration, irrespective of how much money was being offered to me, if I was not able to tell the story of who I am and where I come from. I can make more money by selling on my Instagram," says the designer who went off all social media three years ago to get away from the clutter and the noise. His brand, though, is very active on social media.

MUKHERJEE CAN BE credited with revolutionising luxury retail in the country. Walk into any Sabyasachi store and you are transported to a world of opulence and luxury rarely seen anywhere else. For instance, at the Mumbai store, over 100 chandeliers, 275



carpets, 3,000 books, and 150 works of art created by the Sabyasachi Art Foundation—which he runs to promote art—are layered among antique Tanjore paintings, vintage photography, rare lithographs, and historical trinkets, some from his own collection.

"When I saw the Ralph Lauren flagship store for the first time, it made me realise how important the soft power of a retail store is to be able to influence a customer because it's an immersive journey, which tells the length and the breadth of the brand's story," says Mukherjee, adding that today it is not just about the product but also the experience of selling the product.

With the opening of the Mumbai flagship store, the total number of Sabyasachi stores in India stands at four, the others being in Kolkata and Delhi, and a jewellery store in Hyderabad. In addition, there is the New York store and an exclusive Sabyasachi Jewellery boutique in Dubai.

Will he look at more expansion? Not immediately, he says. "We are going to build our flagship stores one geography at a time. I first want to expand brand literacy by building our flagship so that the story of what the brand is all about and who we are does not get diluted. We will take our time to understand the geography and then expand later," he says. However, a part of the business is going to be opened to wholesale again. "Which means that in a couple of years, we are going to start speaking to departmental stores such as Selfridges, Browns, etc.," These are stores where Mukherjee used to retail at the beginning of his career in 2004-05.

"Right now, I'm charting my own growth, one brick at a time, so that I last those 100 years," he signs off. **BT**

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